credible sources did not confirm it. A few days later, Pakistani and US sources said that Mehsud was not targeted in the drone strike, and one Pakistani source said, 'He is alive. Hakimullah is alive' (*The Express Tribune*, 2012).

The government of Pakistan had been under a greater public pressure after the Salala checkpost incident because the restarting of drone attacks during sour Pak–US relations was being construed as outright aggression by the US. This state of mind of the people of Pakistan suited the TTP and Al Qaeda as it gave them a hope to get rid of the menace of drone attacks. The widening gap between the Pak–US relations was another matter of satisfaction for them.

Was it done with Pakistan's consent?

In fact, the ever-increasing internal public pressure made the government of Pakistan to take a defensive position and constantly deny to have allowed the US to carry out the drone missile attacks inside Pakistan. The former Pakistan Army Chief, General Ashfaq Kayani, while addressing the students of the National Defence University, Islamabad, in May 2011, said that no agreement existed between Pakistan and the US regarding drone attacks nor such agreement had been executed during the previous (Musharraf) regime. Drone attacks were against the national integrity, he added (*The Nation*, 2011). Abdul Basit, the spokesperson of the Foreign Office of Pakistan, also said on 31 January 2012 that the drone attacks were unlawful, counterproductive and hence unacceptable. These remarks from the foreign ministry came as President Barack Obama confirmed for the first time that drone aircraft had targeted militants in Pakistan's tribal areas on the Pak-Afghan border.[4]

Apart from these verbal denials for public consumption, a close scrutiny of the whole affair indicated complicity of Pakistan. The success of drone attack was largely dependent on humint. Unless the target was identified and located by the moles and planted with a chip or mobile phone sim, a drone missile could not locate or track the target. Who were the moles who performed this job and who handled them? There had been different views about it. The government of Pakistan denied its involvement in the drone campaign. Similarly, the Pakistan Army also claimed that it had no role in it. There was a strong evidence that the CIA had direct access in the area, especially in the urban areas through